

Step-by-step reintroduction protocol for suddenly aggressive cats based on Jackson Galaxy methods - with troubleshooting for redirected aggression triggers — Action Checklist

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SET UP EMERGENCY SEPARATION

- ☐ **Immediate Separation:** Set up two complete zones on opposite ends of your home, each containing a litterbox, food, water, and a resting spot, because cats in high-arousal states need absolute separation to begin normalizing their neurochemistry within 72 hours.
- ☐ **Immediate Separation:** Physically move one cat to their assigned zone and close the door completely, because visual and auditory access between cats during this window keeps arousal spiked and deepens the hostile response.
- ☐ **Immediate Separation:** Block all visual access using a solid door or baby gate covered with a blanket if no door exists, because even brief visual contact during the 72-hour normalization window extends the recovery timeline significantly.
- ☐ **Immediate Separation:** Set a 72-hour timer and commit to zero contact between cats until the timer goes off, no matter how calm either cat appears, because their brain chemistry hasn't normalized yet and premature exposure restarts the aggression cycle.

IDENTIFY THE AGGRESSION TYPE

- ☐ **Identify Aggression Type:** Determine whether your cats are experiencing redirected aggression by checking for triggers like outdoor cats at windows, loud construction noises, or new neighborhood activity, because this is the most common cause of sudden collapse in previously peaceful homes.
 - ☐ **Identify Aggression Type:** Read through the four aggression types—status, fear-based, territorial, and redirected—to match your situation, because the recovery timeline varies dramatically from three weeks to three months depending on which type you're dealing with.
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- ☐ **Identify Aggression Type:** Complete the diagnostic worksheet questions in writing, because documenting the circumstances around the first incident helps you identify the actual trigger that caused the relationship collapse rather than just the symptoms.
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- ☐ **Identify Aggression Type:** Place the more stressed cat in the quieter zone with less foot traffic and the other cat in a different zone, because correctly identifying the victim versus the perceived aggressor matters for their emotional recovery.

EXECUTE THE REINTRODUCTION PROTOCOL

- ☐ **Execute Reintroduction Protocol:** Begin scent exchange by swapping bedding or rubbing cloths on each cat and placing them in the other cat's zone, because familiar scent is how cats recognize allies and this begins rebuilding positive associations before visual contact.
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- ☐ **Execute Reintroduction Protocol:** Progress through phases with specific advance-or-pause checkpoints, moving from full separation to scent swapping to controlled visual access through a barrier before any face-to-face meetings, because recovery isn't linear and cats signal their readiness at each stage.
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- ☐ **Execute Reintroduction Protocol:** Use a baby gate for the first supervised visual contact sessions, allowing brief controlled glimpses rather than open access, because this lets you monitor body language and interrupt any pilo-erection or stalking behavior before it escalates.
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- ☐ **Execute Reintroduction Protocol:** Watch for readiness signals like relaxed body posture, slow blinking, and voluntary proximity before advancing each phase, because pushing too fast creates setbacks and the cats will tell you when they're prepared to move forward.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.